

Setting Up Measurement

Two free tools, four settings that most people get wrong, and a baseline you cannot create retroactively.

Bottom line

Search Console and GA4 are free and non-negotiable. Both ship with defaults that will cost you later, and one of them, GA4's two-month data retention, destroys history you can never recover. Fix the defaults, record a baseline today, and Tier 1 is done.

The measurement triangle

Three sources answer three different questions, and no single one is sufficient.

Source	Answers	Limitation
Search Console	What happens in Google search: queries, impressions, clicks, position, indexing	Google only. Anonymizes low-volume queries. 16-month cap
GA4	What happens after the click: pages, engagement, conversions	Misattributes a lot of organic. Sampling and consent gaps
CRM / business data	Whether it produced money	Attribution is imperfect and always will be

The goal is **decision-grade data, not precision**. Privacy changes, consent banners and AI referrers have permanently broken exact attribution. Anyone promising perfect measurement is selling something.

Search Console setup

1. Verify a Domain property, not a URL-prefix property. A Domain property covers every subdomain and both protocols in one place. URL-prefix properties silently miss traffic on variants you forgot about. Verification is a DNS TXT record.

2. Submit your XML sitemap. Usually `/sitemap.xml` or `/sitemap_index.xml`. Section 22 covers what belongs in it. For now, submit and confirm it is read.

3. Learn four reports and ignore the rest for now.

- **Performance.** Queries, pages, impressions, clicks, CTR, position. Where you will spend most of your time.

- **Pages** (indexing). Which URLs are indexed and why the rest are not. You read this in Section 2.
- **Core Web Vitals**. Field data, mobile is what matters. Tier 3.
- **Generative AI Performance**. Launched mid-2026, reports performance inside AI Mode and AI Overviews. New, and the only first-party window into AI surfaces you get.

4. Use the 28-day rolling view for routine checks. Daily numbers are noise, and the 28-day average smooths it. [practitioner]

5. Know the 16-month cap. Search Console keeps 16 months and then it is gone. If you care about longer history, export monthly to a sheet or connect it to Looker Studio. Nobody does this until they need data from 18 months ago and discover it does not exist.

GA4 setup, and the settings that matter

1. Extend data retention to 14 months. Admin, Data Settings, Data Retention. **The default is 2 months.** Two months makes year-over-year comparison impossible, and the setting is not retroactive. Changing it today does not recover what was already discarded. If you do one thing from this section, do this one. [confirmed]

2. Link Search Console to GA4. Admin, Product Links, Search Console Links. This brings query-level data into GA4 and lets you connect a query to what happened after the click.

3. Understand the misattribution problem. GA4's default channel grouping misclassifies roughly **30 to 50% of search traffic** as Direct or Unassigned. Your organic traffic is almost certainly higher than GA4 reports. [practitioner]

The practical detection trick: look at Direct traffic landing on **deep pages, four or more URL segments**. Nobody types a URL that long. That traffic is almost always misclassified organic. [practitioner]

4. Set up an AI referral channel group. As of July 2026 GA4 has a native AI Assistant channel covering ChatGPT, Gemini and Claude, but **it excludes AI Overviews**, which still report as Organic Search. For a custom group, this regex covers the main sources:

```
``.(chatgpt.com|openai.com|perplexity.ai|claude.ai|gemini.google.com|copilot.microsoft.com|you.com|grok.x.ai).``
```

Be aware GA4 undercounts AI referrals by **8 to 31%** against server logs, because AI platforms often use `rel="noreferrer"` which strips the referrer entirely. Server log analysis is the only ground truth, and that is Section 41. [practitioner]

5. Define conversions. At minimum: form submissions, calls, and whatever counts as a lead. Traffic without conversion data cannot be prioritized, because you cannot tell which pages produce anything.

Record the baseline

This is the part people skip and later regret. Today, before Tier 2 changes anything, write down:

Metric	Source
Total clicks and impressions, last 28 days	Search Console Performance
Average position and CTR	Search Console Performance
Number of indexed pages	Search Console Pages
Count in "Crawled - not indexed" and "Discovered - not indexed"	Search Console Pages
Core Web Vitals status, mobile	Search Console CWV
Organic sessions and conversions, last 28 days	GA4
Position for each of your top 10 target queries	Search Console, filter by query
AI mention baseline for your 10 queries	Your Section 1 and Section 5 notes

Date it. Everything you do from here is measured against this row, and you cannot create it retroactively.

What good looks like

Rough orientation rather than targets, since these vary enormously by site and market:

- **Indexed-to-submitted ratio above 85%** is healthy. [practitioner]
- **Impressions rising while clicks stay flat** means visibility without relevance, usually ranking for the wrong things.
- **A mature SEO program returns 3 to 5x its cost.** Median reported SEO ROI across industries is **748%**, which is a practitioner figure with wide variance behind it. [practitioner]
- **Organic CPA should run 40 to 70% of paid search CPA.** If it is not cheaper than ads, something is wrong. [practitioner]

The one report to run weekly

Search Console, Performance, last 28 days, sorted by impressions, filtered to positions 5 to 15.

That view is where the cheapest wins live. Those pages already rank and already earn impressions. From Section 5: moving position 8 to position 4 is roughly **400% more clicks** from content you already have. Every week, pick one row and improve it.

Why this matters

the two-month GA4 retention default has quietly destroyed more useful history than any algorithm update. And an undated, unrecorded baseline means that in six months you will not be able to prove anything worked, which matters for your own learning and matters more when a client asks.

Do this now

- 1 **Verify a Domain property in Search Console** if you have not already.
- 2 **Submit your sitemap** and confirm it is read.
- 3 **Open GA4, Admin, Data Settings, Data Retention, and set it to 14 months.** Do this first, it is the only irreversible one.
- 4 **Link Search Console to GA4** in Admin, Product Links.
- 5 **Create the AI referral channel group** using the regex above.
- 6 **Confirm at least one conversion is defined** and firing.
- 7 **Check Direct traffic landing on deep pages** and note roughly how much misclassified organic you appear to have.
- 8 **Fill in the baseline table** and date it. Save it somewhere you will find in six months.
- 9 **Run the positions 5 to 15 report** and note the top three opportunities.

Capstone step

Tier 1 is complete. Your capstone site now has: a baseline audit, verified measurement, a keyword map with one page per intent, cannibalization identified, one page properly optimized, and a dated baseline of every number that matters. Tier 2 works through the content layer against that map.

Key takeaways

- GA4 defaults to **2 months** of data retention. Set it to 14 immediately, because the setting is not retroactive and year-over-year comparison is impossible without it.
- GA4 misclassifies 30 to 50% of search traffic as Direct or Unassigned. Direct traffic on deep URLs is the tell.
- Search Console keeps 16 months and then deletes. Export if you want longer history.
- Record a dated baseline before changing anything. It is the only way to prove later that any of this worked.